SPEAKING TRUTH TO AMERICAN POWER

NAMAL RAJAPAKSA, *Member of Parliament, Sri Lanka*



The sinking of the Iranian Navy ship IRIS *Dena* in the Indian Ocean off Galle by a US submarine is a "question of Indian Ocean identity" because the waters are known to be a safe zone, Sri Lankan MP Namal Rajapaksa told the audience at the India Today conclave. "If you look at the legality of it, it can be argued as illegal. And the question is whether there is an international law in today's context." Rajapaksa said. "Ethics and moral values were clearly broken. Are we going to allow it in the future?" he asked. "All regional nations must get together to make sure that we keep our area safe. I believe India has a major role to play as a great power." Rajapaksa also believes that, as a non-aligned nation, Sri Lanka ought to ask for an explanation from the US about the incident and must take a principled stand on any US diktat against the repatriation of the Iranian sailors.

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> **They (US) may have power...financial power. They must understand their decisions will have an impact on islands like us. They have to make sure the world order is in place**

The MP also said that his nation is facing a fuel crisis due to the Iran conflict. Foreign remittances from West Asia and tourism can also be affected, he added. On other issues, he said Sri Lanka must engage afresh with Tamil Nadu, emphasised that Katchatheevu island is Lankan territory and refuted all past corruption allegations against the prominent Rajapaksa political clan. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Sri Lanka must seek an explanation for sinking IRIS *Dena* and take a principled stand on any US diktat against repatriating Iranian sailors**
- **Colombo must start a dialogue and re-strategise dealing with Tamil Nadu as the war with the LTTE is long over**